

Social Design Framework

Social Design is not neutral. Every design decision carries values, assumptions, and consequences, shaping not only what becomes possible but also what is discouraged or prevented.

Because of this, we must think carefully about which elements to consider when designing new European Social Platforms. Responsible social design requires anticipation of unintended outcomes, power dynamics, and long-term societal effects. At the same time, social systems should be understood through organic metaphors of resilience and growth rather than purely mechanical optimization.

Therefore, we are updating the Social Design Framework v0.8, reflecting current needs and trajectories of Social Platform design in the near future and beyond, helping builders to make informed decisions in the early stages of new platform design and development—by integrating input from the other Rebuilt track workgroups in the midterm.

Healthy systems evolve, adapt, and recover; they contain tensions that are not simply right or wrong, but productive forces that can generate learning and transformation. Recognizing and working with these tensions is essential for creating Social Platforms that are durable, ethical, and life-affirming.

Borrowing from biology, we are describing Social Platforms as living organisms, i.e., something that is alive and can learn, with properties that help the platform system to protect itself from harm (such as an immune system protecting itself from internal and external harm).



ENABLE
Supporting platform builders to get started building healthy social platforms.

GROW
Supporting platform builders to design for sustainable platform growth.

PROTECT
Supporting platform builders to design a platform immune system to identify internal and external threads

- 1. Social Object** is the shared “thing” that mediates ties between people – i.e., the reason these people interact with each other (and not with everyone). The object can be material or immaterial.
- 2. Platform Intent** (Business driven / ROI = Return on Investment) versus **Experience Intent** (User driven / ROX = Return on Experience).
- 3. Identity**
How much users reveal who they are (name, demographics, profession, location, self-presentation/self-disclosure). How are you balancing identity vs privacy and context-specific identities.
- 4. Conversations**
How are users able to communicate with each other). How are users able to talk, comment and interact.
- 5. Sharing**
The extent to which users exchange/distribute/ receive content the “objects of sociality” (the shared object that ties people together—text, video, links, deals, locations). Implications include copyright/offensive content controls.
- 6. Presence**
Whether users can know if others are available/ accessible, and often where they are (status, online/offline, location check-ins). Connects to immediacy/intimacy: higher presence can make interactions more influential.
- 7. Relationships**
How users connect/associate (friend/follow contacts, degrees of separation).
- 8. Reputation**
How users can assess standing/trustworthiness of people and content (followers, endorsements, likes/ ratings, view counts). *Implication:* choose metrics that match what the community values (popularity vs quality vs activity over time)
- 9. Groups**
The ability to form communities/sub-communities (lists, open/closed/secret groups) and manage membership. Implications include permissions, filtering, and complexity when identities/roles overlap (e.g., colleague + friend).
- 10. Agency**
How users can take control of their experiences on the social platform (immune response to protect user attention).